

SOC Investigation Report

High-Confidence Phishing Email | Authorized Microsoft 365 Lab Simulation

Field	Investigation finding
Investigation date	October 7, 2026
Platform	Microsoft Defender XDR / Defender for Office 365
Case disposition	Informational, expected activity — Security testing (recommended)
Investigation scope	Simulated phishing email, delivery, URL interaction, authentication headers, identity context

Executive summary

An authorized phishing simulation used an urgent Microsoft 365 account-verification pretext and an IT-support impersonation theme. Defender identified the message as high-confidence phishing, blocked normal inbox delivery, and placed it in quarantine. No URL clicks were observed in the reviewed telemetry, and no sign-in was established as resulting from the email. The evidence supports successful email containment; it does not establish that unrelated identity activity was caused by this message.

Email and detection findings

Indicator	Result
Subject	Action Required: Microsoft 365 Account Verification
Threat verdict	Phish / High; protection category HPHISH
Detection methods	Advanced filter; impersonation user
Spam confidence level	SCL 8; spam filtering verdict SPM
Delivery	Blocked; quarantined; no normal inbox delivery
Test URL	example.com/security-verification (reserved example domain)
URL reputation	No malicious detections reported in user-performed VirusTotal check
Recipient interactions	No URL clicks observed

Email authentication and content analysis

The receiving authentication results showed SPF, DKIM, DMARC and composite authentication passing. The headers also contained earlier ARC-chain entries recording no authentication result at an intermediate stage; these should not be confused with the final receiving verdict. Authentication verifies sender-domain authorization and message integrity characteristics, not the legitimacy of the email's request.

Phishing indicators included an urgent 24-hour verification deadline, a warning about restricted account access, IT-support impersonation and a verification call to action. The message also contained an explicit lab simulation disclaimer.

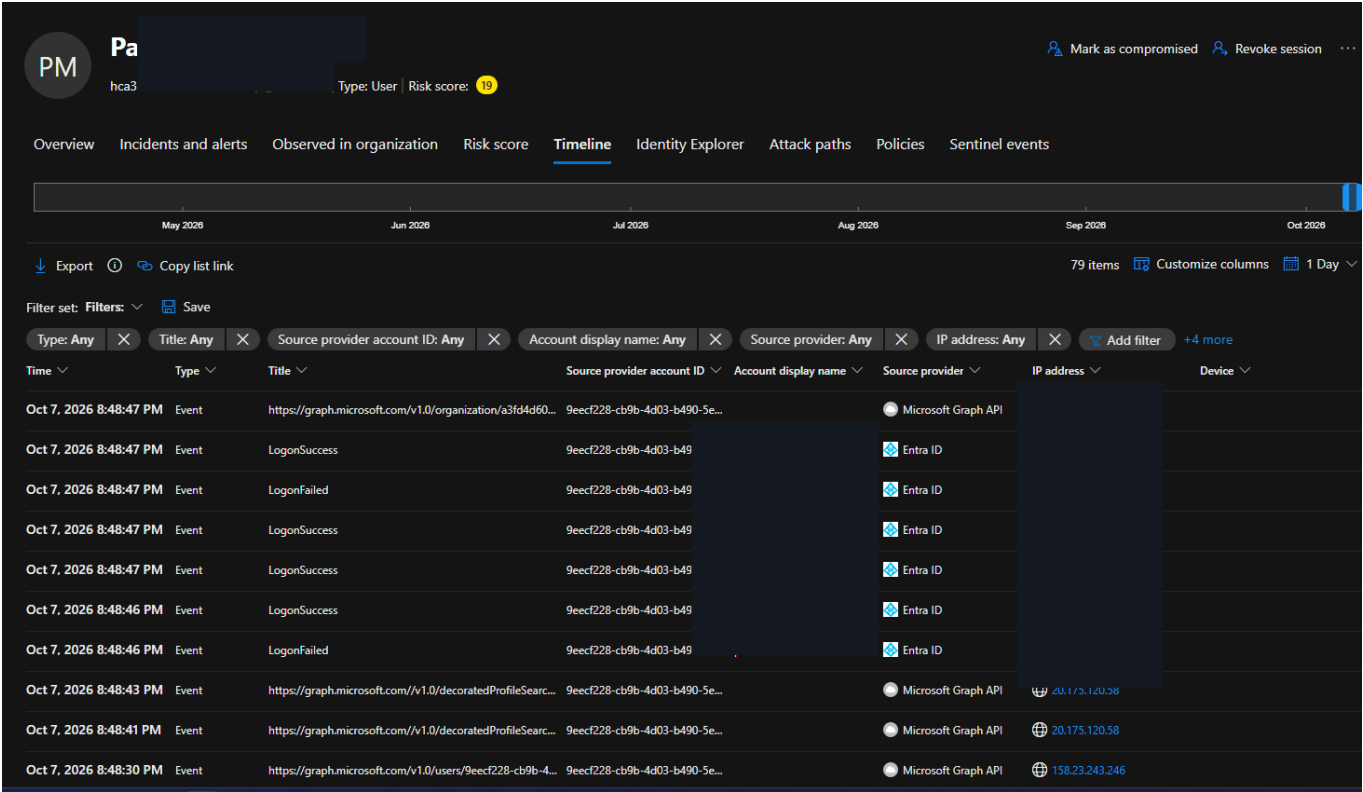
Impact and containment

No additional recipients were identified in the evidence reviewed. No URL clicks were observed. Quarantine was the observed containment mechanism. There was no evidence in the reviewed material linking the email to a successful credential compromise or account takeover. These are evidence-limited findings, not proof that every possible telemetry source was exhausted.

Identity context — separate findings

Recipient timeline

The recipient identity timeline displayed 79 events, including successful and failed sign-in events and Microsoft Graph API activity. Multiple IP addresses appeared, including an address beginning with 70., which has been fully redacted from the portfolio screenshot. The timeline alone does not establish malicious activity or a causal link to the quarantined email.

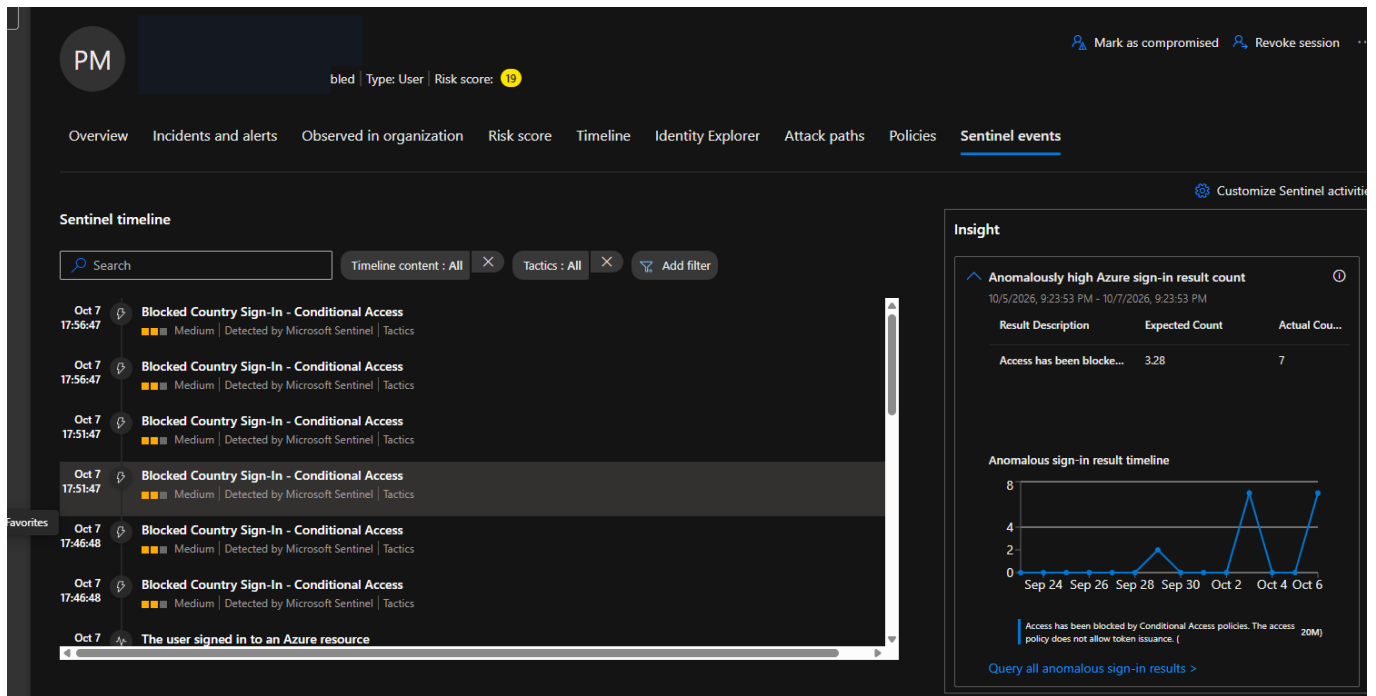


Evidence A — Defender identity timeline. User identifiers and IP-address column have been obscured for public sharing.

Sentinel Conditional Access detections

The Sentinel view showed repeated “Blocked Country Sign-In - Conditional Access” detections with Medium severity. An insight indicated seven blocked sign-in results compared with an expected count of 3.28. These are evidence of blocked access attempts, not evidence that the phishing email succeeded. Successful Azure-resource sign-in entries require separate event-level review if the identity investigation remains open.

Supporting evidence and disposition



Evidence B — Microsoft Sentinel identity events. Account name and tenant identifier have been obscured.

Analyst assessment

Email incident: Authorized phishing simulation; correctly detected and quarantined. No observed URL clicks. No evidence attributable to this message of successful account compromise. Recommended disposition: Informational, expected activity — Security testing, if a Defender incident exists. A quarantined email does not itself require incident closure or release.

Identity events: Keep separate from the email case unless correlation evidence (such as click telemetry, timestamps, device/session identifiers, and sign-in context) establishes a connection. Do not mark the identity as compromised solely on the basis of this authorized email simulation.

Evidence handling and limitations

Screenshots were raster-redacted for portfolio use. The IP-address column on the Defender identity timeline, including the address starting with 70., was obscured. Other visible user and tenant identifiers were also covered. The report omits raw mail headers and unredacted email identifiers to reduce accidental exposure. Preserve originals privately for audit or future lab comparison.

This report documents findings supplied in the investigation; it does not assert that every Defender or Entra telemetry source was independently verified. Status is “investigation complete” for the simulated email; no claim is made that a corresponding incident was actually marked Resolved in the portal.